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Data and Tech Standards for Children's Social Care

Placement Standards Working Group 3

5 November 2025

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PRIVATE AND CONFIDENTIAL

Things to be aware of

Conflicts of interest – Please inform the chair / secretariat if you think there is a risk.

Anti-competitive activities – Please inform the chair / secretariat if you think there is a risk of anti-competitive activity.

Intellectual Property - If you are concerned about the use of your contributions, please contact the secretariat.

Meeting Recording - We will record this meeting and using AI transcription tools.

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Principles for group

1. Every voice matters
2. Please join in on the conversation, we don’t want this to be one way
3. If you’re happy to, keep your camera on
4. Please raise your hand if you want to come in, or drop your ideas in the chat
5. Respect the diverse viewpoints in the room, assume positive intent and remain open for different experiences

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Agenda

1. Reminder – what are we setting out to do?
2. What progress have we made since we last met?
3. What decisions have been made
4. What’s left to do to finalise the standard
5. What else should we be considering?

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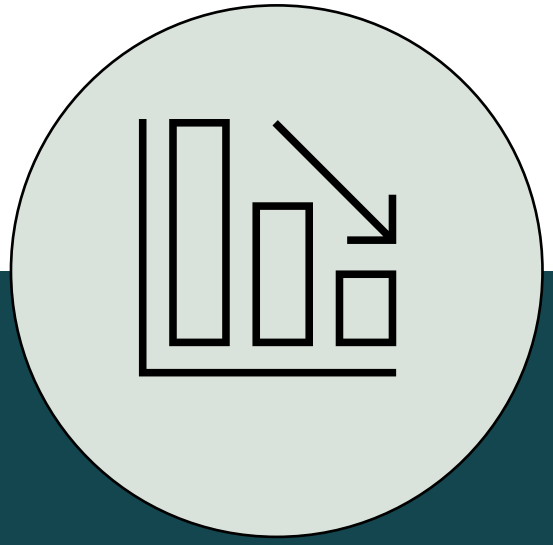
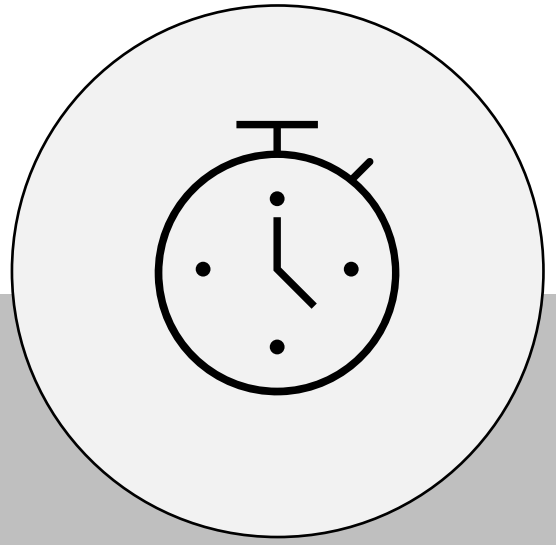
Reminder - Programme Overview

We're interested in using standards to drive four key benefits:

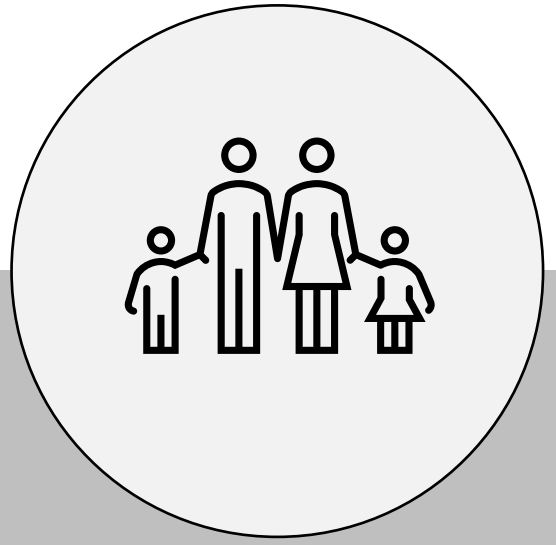
Improved data sharing to support safeguarding decisions



Better data analysis and strategic decision making



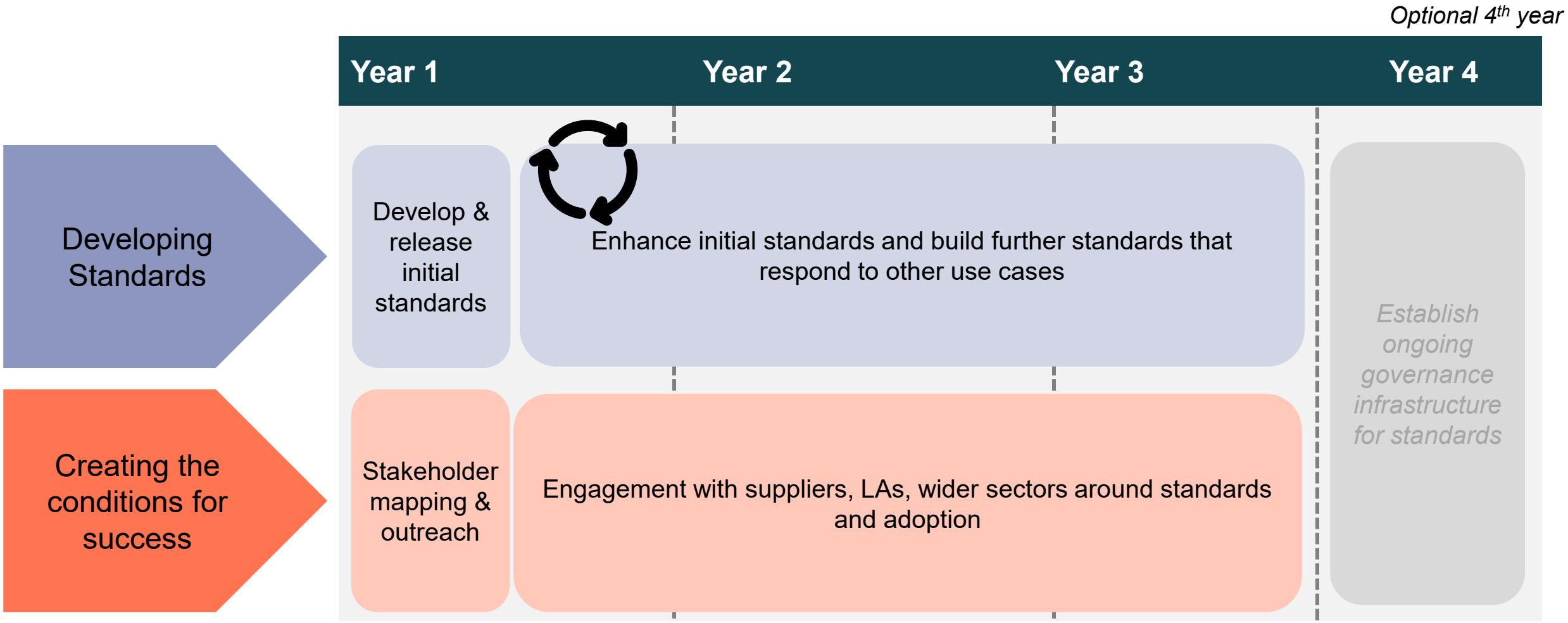
Improved productivity for social workers and a reduction in tech inhibiting processes



Increased power sharing with children and families

FOCUS FOR THIS GROUP

What might the next 3 years look like to help us solve the problems in the market using standards?



Our placements roadmap, based on your input to date

NOW
(decided by Steering Committee)

Better Sufficiency Analysis

What provision where, at what cost and at what notice would help us meet the unmet demand and what is the business case for creating this provision?

NEXT?

- Supporting standardization of need assessments
- eBrokerage
- Better analysis of what could reduce demand
- 'Front door' referrals into CSC
- Child voice
- Outcomes tracking
- Fostering supply
- *What else…?*

Who is here today?

Something went wrong...

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Progress we've made so far

Reminder: proposed objectives for Placement Standard workstream

So that…

1. **Standard Dramatically Improves Sufficiency Analysis**

   LAs can answer: **what type of provision is needed where and in what volumes**? And what is the business case for doing it in each LA (or in partnership)?

2. **Standard Is Easy to Adopt**

   Placements teams can **enter the data in 90 seconds** or less

3. **Implementation Support is Effective and Affordable**

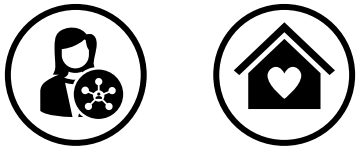
   LAs are able to implement and **benefit from a new standard quickly** within existing resource

Process for reaching resolving each design issue

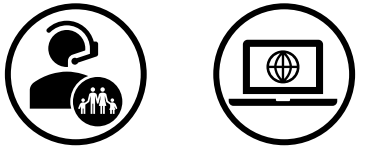
1. Working Group invited to **build out the 'long list'** of deep dive issues
2. Programme team gathers and **consolidates all comments** raised on each issue, ensuring input from all key perpsectives
4. Attendees at **Deep Dive reach position** to feed back to wider Working Group
3. If there is consensus, **Working Group endorses** and recommends to Steering Committee
5. **Standard remains open** on Github for comments (to review standard periodically)

For each decision, we're testing our thinking against these criteria & perspectives

SCOPE
Does it help us answer key sufficiency questions?



FEASIBILTY
Can it be gathered in <90 seconds without requiring change from CMS vendors?



ADDITIONALITY
Are we sure we're not duplicating existing data?

OTHER IMPACTS
Are we sure there are no unintended impacts?

Where are we up to?

5 Issues resolved in Deep Dives and endorsed by Working Group

RESOLVED:

- ✓ 3 issues related to how we describe the **actual placement**
- ✓ 2 issues how we describe **placement requirements** and child needs

Resolved in Deep Dives; with Working Group today for endorsement

- Describing **placement cost**
- Describing preferred and actual **location**
- **Implementation** approach

Issues to keep 'open' through next implementation phase

- **Engaging providers** to test our approach
- Describing and capturing **cost**
- Describing preferred **location**
- Learning how **commissioners** use the data
- Best approach to **QA**

Decision – describing placement cost

Issue	Perspectives consulted	Issue raised in deep dives and SW pilot	Resolution
Describing the cost of a placement	Commissioners and DCSs Providers and IFAs Placement workers CMS & software suppliers Finance Leads	• Accuracy of the data likely to be highly sensitive to when it is gathered • Hard to distinguish 'core' from 'total' fee as high degree of variability in the way this is recorded	• **Use an already-validated cost data approach** (PNW) that defines cost as 'total weekly fee' and is gathered quarterly • **Keep issue 'open'** and review based on pilot learning • **Run a small study** to understand data variation in more depth

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Decision – describing location

Issue	Perspectives consulted	Issue raised in deep dives and SW pilot	Resolution agreed
Describing preferred location	Commissioners and DCSs Performance, data & tech leads Placement workers CMS & software suppliers	• Free-text likely to hinder analytical insight • Pre-determined list of geographies risks being either too high level or too detailed to be accurate or knowable	• **Use Excel lookup** to allow copy pasting regions from a custom predefined list • **Keep issue open** to review what level of geographic specificity is most suitable

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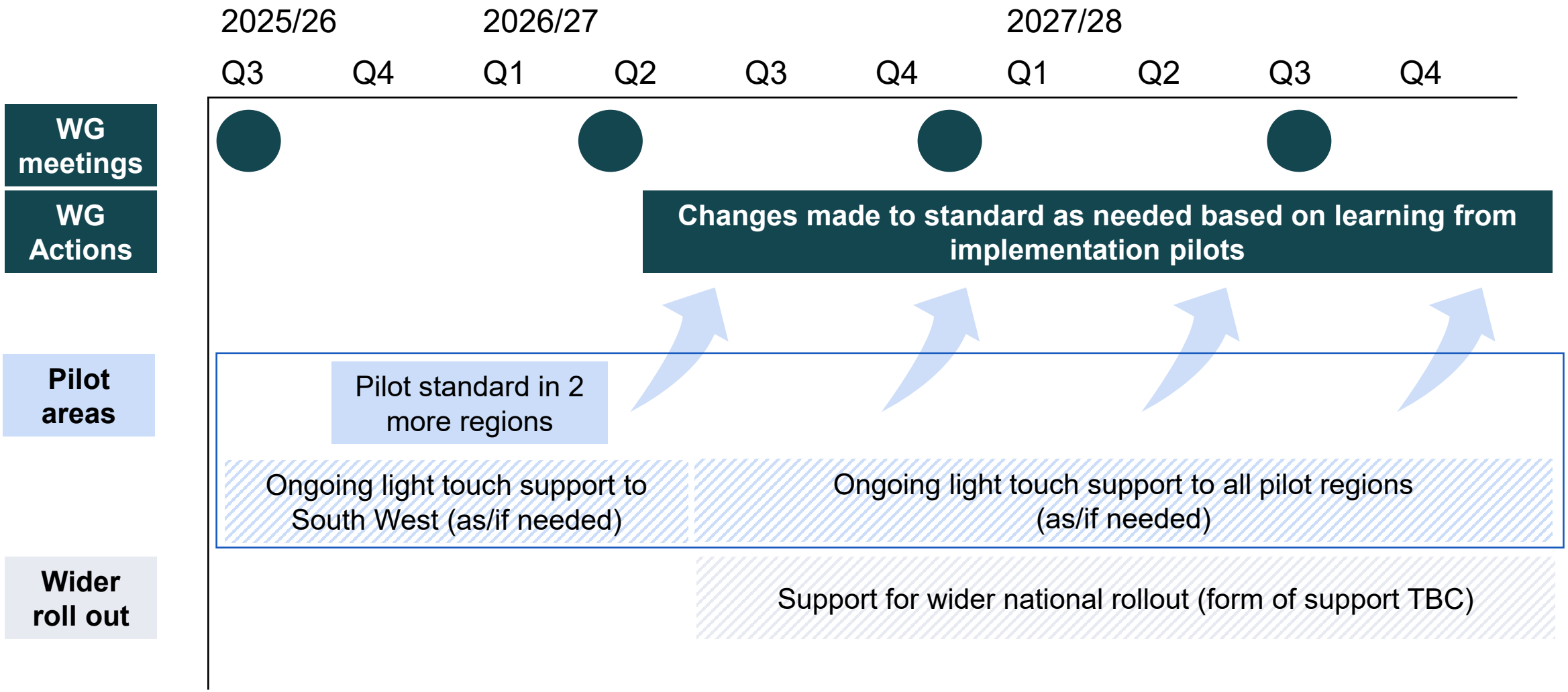
Refresh

Implementation approach

	Upfront	*Ongoing*
To *adopt the standard*, LAs need:	➢ Strong DCS sponsorship ➢ Accountable lead (c. 1-3 days to update trackers) ➢ IT team to support software changes if needed (e.g. CMS workflow/forms)	➢ *<90 seconds data entry per placement* ➢ *Monthly data QA by accountable lead*
To *enable LAs*, regions need:	➢ DCS champion/s ➢ Regional hub to coordinate ➢ Implementation support to LAs (c. 0.5 FTE x 6 months) ➢ Person-level DSAs	➢ *Regional data and performance team accountable for QA, process improvement and analysis*

Role of the working group going forward



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Are you happy for us to move into the *Implementation phase*

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Yes,	Yes, with further comments noted	Do not proceed, further discussion needed

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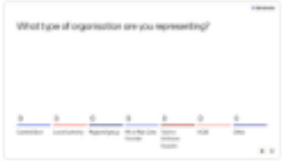
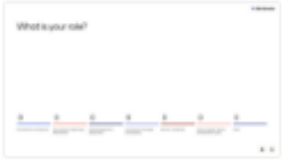
Placement Standard W...

Choose a slide to present

What next for other standards?

NOW (decided by Steering Committee)	NEXT?	
Better Sufficiency Analysis	Child need assessments	Embedding child voice
	eBrokerage	Child outcomes tracking
	Better analysis of what could reduce demand	Monitoring fostering supply
	'Front door' referrals into CSC	*What else…?*

Considering: *Burden of change on LAs, CMS supplier changes , Need for new tech infrastructure*

APPENDIX

Decisions Log – Describing the actual placement

Issue	Resolution agreed	% Working Group accepting resolution
Describing the actual placement	• **Explore further** adding an option to specify top 3 priorities for placement and whether they were achieved to include in a 'silver/gold' version of the standard (rather than in the MVP)	81%
Describing Placement type	• **Add** external / internal distinction • **Explore further** whether we add regulated / unregulated distinction, noting possible practicality constraints	
Describing if siblings were split	• **Change** 'where siblings split' to 'How many siblings were placed together' • **Add** 'Where there was a sibling group, was placement according to plan' with options: 'Yes, No, N/A'	
Describing Placement requirements	• **Drop** 'preferred staffing ratio' • **Change** 'can child live with pets' drop down to 'yes-must, yes-can, no, not known' • **Further test** list of placement requirement determinants of availability with providers.	88%
Describing Risks to child and others	• **Add** DOL (not yet user tested) • **Change** drop down for risks to 'no known risk' / 'risk present' • **Further test** list of risks with providers (e.g. via survey)	

Decisions Log – Describing the actual placement

Issue	Key perspectives	Issue discussed	Resolution agreed
Describing the actual placement	Commissioners and DCSs; Providers and IFAs	• Actual placements described by: Location, Type, Provider URN, and whether siblings were split up • Discussed whether this was the right list for commissioners to understand sufficiency gaps at a high level	• **Explore further** adding an option to specify top 3 priorities for placement and whether they were achieved to include in a 'silver/gold' version of the standard (rather than in the MVP)
Describing Placement type	Commissioners and DCSs; Providers and IFAs; Performance, data & tech leads; Placement workers	• Placement type described by list: Foster, Residential, Supported Accommodation. • Is this list sufficient for commissioners to understand gap between ideal and actual placement type?	• **Add** external / internal distinction • **Explore further** whether we add regulated / unregulated distinction, noting possible practicality constraints
Describing if siblings were split	Commissioners and DCSs; Placement workers; Children & Family Voice	• Whether siblings were split is described by options: Y/N • Is the description of whether siblings were split up (a) able to be gathered by placement workers and (b) granular enough to be useful?	• **Change** 'where siblings split' to 'How many siblings were placed together' • **Add** 'Where there was a sibling group, was placement according to plan' with options: 'Yes, No, N/A'

Decisions Log – Describing what determines placement availability

Issue	Key perspectives	Issue discussed	Resolution agreed
Describing Placement requirements	Commissioners and DCSs; Placement workers; Performance, data & tech leads; Providers and IFAs	• This section captures what providers told us in initial testing what matters most when deciding to offer placement • Is it this list (a) practical for a placement worker to gather this information and (b) sufficiently nuanced for commissioners to understand drivers of placement availability	• **Drop** 'preferred staffing ratio' • **Change** 'can child live with pets' drop down to 'yes-must, yes-can, no, not known' • **Further test** list of placement requirement determinants of availability with providers.
Describing Risks to child and others	Commissioners and DCSs; Placement workers; Performance, data & tech leads; Providers and IFAs	• This section captures what providers told us in initial testing what matters most when deciding to offer placement • Is it this list (a) practical for a placement worker to gather this information and (b) sufficiently nuanced for commissioners to understand drivers of placement availability	• **Add** DOL (not yet user tested) • **Change** drop down for risks to 'no known risk' / 'risk present' • **Further test** list of risks with providers (e.g. via survey)

Decision – describing location

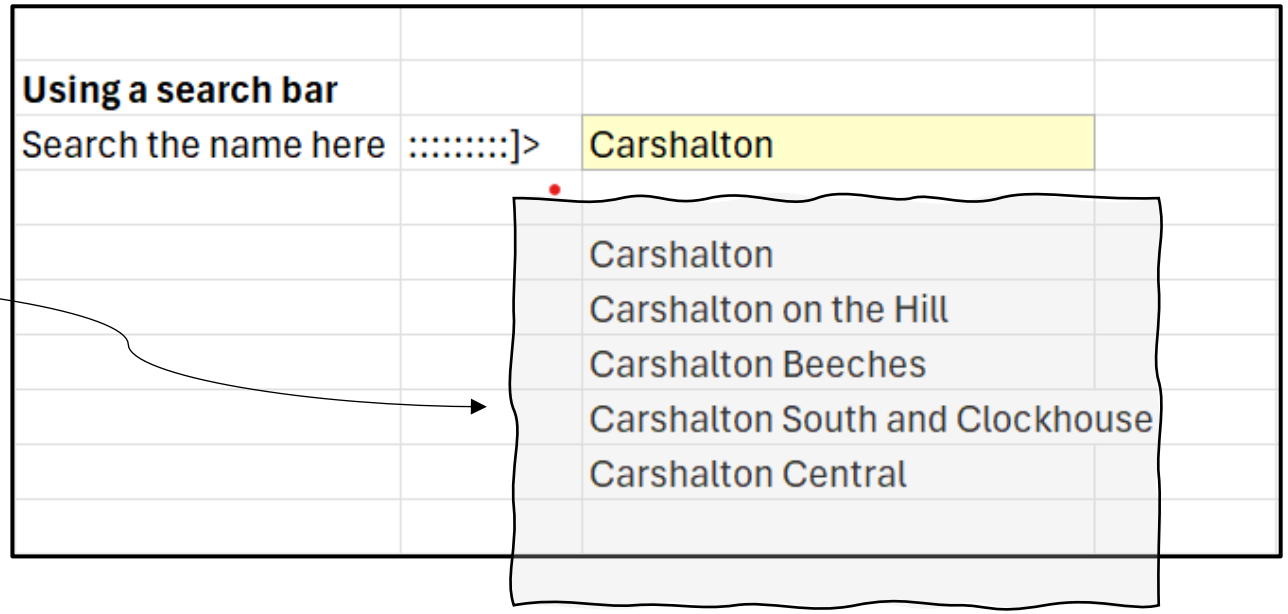
How do we meaningfully capture a child's preferred placement location?

Solutions we tried	Challenges identified through Deep Dives
❑ Open text box to describe child's preferred area	• Inconsistent entries ("near school," "Somerset," "Bath area") • Limits analytical use. • Time consuming to clean
❑ Capturing postcode	• Placement officers may not have or know it at the matching stage • Time consuming and error prone entry • Incomplete data risk
Resolution adopted	
❑ Excel lookup with predefined region names.	• Easier and faster for placement team searching with names of places, consistent format for analysis, • Next focus will to be finding the right level of geographic specificity.
❑ Field to sense check location from the placement offc.	• Adding a separate sense check field – was the actual location the child's preferred area? provides additional accuracy
❑ Mapping education continuity	• Added field on education continuity to provide further nuance around whether the placement was preferred, all else equal, and in line with suggestions raised during deep dive discussion about the importance of educational continuity (in many, but not all placements)

Decision – describing location

Excel lookup function for Preferred Location

1. A separate search bar to enter the region name
2. Based on the search bar a list of regions appears.
3. Placement officer can copy and paste the region in the referral form



Advantages

- Easier and faster for placement team searching with names of places over postcodes
- Consistent format for analysis